BEST LIFE WITH ROSE

The Travel Playbook

Packing List & Budget

Here's how I travel. Steal what works.

I'm Rose, a nurse in New Jersey. I moved to the US in January 2023 and I've been exploring ever since, all on a nurse's salary. This isn't an expert manual. It's my personal playbook, built from real trips and real mistakes.

A free guide from Rose

THE PACKING EDIT

Pack like you've done this before.

Tell me where you're going and for how long. I'll build the list I'd use myself, then you make it yours.

MY TRIP

Trip type

Trip length

Bag plan

ROSE'S REAL RULES

- [ ] First trip? Start with the full list, then remove anything you know you will not use.
- [ ] A few trips in? Use the outfit math to cut duplicates before they reach the bag.
- [ ] Frequent flyer? Try carry-on only and edit the list down to your repeat essentials.

MY PACKING LIST

Outfits that repeat, first. Everything else has to earn its place in the bag.

My repeat essentials:

POINTS

How I stretch my travel budget with points.

I'm not a points expert. I'm a nurse who learned by doing, and got a few things wrong along the way. Here's what I wish someone had told me at the start.

WHERE I STARTED

- [ ] Keep points flexible until plans are certain. When uncertainty exists, like waiting on a visa, flexibility beats max value.
- [ ] For my Italy flight, I booked through Chase Travel for 83,518 points + $0 cash instead of transferring to United. "It provides more security cause I can rebook."

WHAT I GOT WRONG

- [ ] Never transfer a full balance speculatively. Find the exact award flight first, confirm the mileage price, then transfer only the number of points needed.
- [ ] Compare final checkout totals, not teaser prices. One booking site showed $372 but $465 at checkout. The portal showed $571.33 minus my $100 credit, which came to $471.33. That was only $6.33 more, so I kept my points.

WHAT I'D DO AGAIN

- [ ] Annual credits first. Use-it-or-lose-it benefits get spent before points are burned. I use my $100 annual hotel credit by booking through the travel portal to trigger it, then I apply points to the rest.
- [ ] Use free night awards on the most expensive nights. I target the priciest stays for award redemptions.

MY WALLET

Chase Sapphire Preferred — Ultimate Rewards points, with 1:1 transfers to airline partners like United.
Capital One Venture X — my default everyday card.
United Explorer — free checked bag when the ticket is bought with the card.
Marriott Bonvoy Boundless — part of the setup I use for hotel stays.
Transfer partners I have used: United MileagePlus, Air Canada Aeroplan, Singapore KrisFlyer, Emirates Skywards, and Air France Flying Blue.

THE MONEY PAGE

Know your number before you book.

A trip feels lighter when you know what it costs. Plug in your budget and see where every dollar goes.

How I think about it: the trip budget is really the extra you spend because you're there. I count only incremental spend beyond everyday life.

MY TRIP

Total budget

Trip length (days)

Number of travelers

MY BUDGET

The example column is the playbook's starting point. Write your own number beside it.

Category	Example	My number
Flights	$700	
Stay	$900	
Food	$300	
Transport	$150	
Activities	$200	
Shopping	$0	
Buffer	$250	
Total	**$2,500**	

TWO RULES I NEVER SKIP

My 10% buffer habit.

I always keep a little cushion. Future me says thank you.

THE SPLURGE RULE

Budget a small cash splurge, a spa, a tour, a nice dinner, to reward yourself for doing life boldly.

BEFORE YOU APPLY FOR ANYTHING

My pause-before-you-click list.

- [ ] Know your budget.
- [ ] Never carry a balance chasing rewards.
- [ ] Read the fine print.
- [ ] Check current offers on the issuer's site.

BEGINNER GLOSSARY

Points — rewards earned in a credit card program. Some can be used in a travel portal or transferred to partners.
Miles — rewards held inside an airline loyalty program and used under that program's rules.
Transfer partners — airline or hotel programs that can receive points from a credit card rewards program.
Annual fee — the amount a card charges each year for keeping the account open.
Statement credit — a credit that reduces the amount shown on your card statement when its terms are met.

Your next trip starts here.

Take what helps. Leave what doesn't. Make it yours.

This playbook shares my personal experience and is not financial, medical, or professional travel advice. Offers change fast. Always check the airline or card issuer before you decide.